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# Victor Rendón Part II
# (The Covid Interview)

*The Covid-19 pandemic impacted the music and arts community particularly hard. Musicians who had previously been interviewed for the Fillius Jazz Archive graciously shared their experiences during this virtual shutdown period. The political and racial unrest occurring simultaneously was also addressed.*

*Victor was interviewed via Zoom on June 12, 2020, by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.*

MR: My name is Monk Rowe, it is June 12. I'm happy to have Victor Rendón here with me, percussionist and educator and band leader, to sort of talk about the state of your life and career. Thanks for joining.

VR: Oh, thank you for having me, Monk.

MR: Was there a particular day you remember, in March I'm guessing, where things started to be cancelled for you?

VR: Most definitely. The last date that I played with my band was March 10th at the Nuyorican. It was on a Tuesday. And it hadn't really hit anybody, at least me. I was aware that we were having a problem with the pandemic but it didn't hit home yet. It really hit the next day, Wednesday because I had a percussion ensemble recital on the 12th and I had a group from Ireland that came in to perform with us, and I had another group from Baltimore, Maryland. And they were all here and we were ready to go. We had this big recital to present. But that's when everything became questionable as to whether we could perform with larger groups. So the college really didn't have an answer whether, for me to go on or not. So I was sort of like in limbo. Should I let all these people down and just cancel everything? Just go back home you know. Or go on and take a chance. So it was really something that I really had to think about. What it came down to by the evening of March 11th I decided that I was going to wait for a definite cue from the dean of the school. I just waited for the higher ups to tell me what was supposed to happen. So I got together with the person that helps me move things, and we moved the essential stuff to the room. I don't have to do it but, you know, I always help anyway. And I said, "Well if we go on then we'll move the small stuff in the morning, and we're good to go." As it happened, when I got home I had an email from the dean announcing to everybody that we couldn't get together in large groups. So that was the final decision. But it was a tough one because it fell on me, at the beginning, on me to make a decision, and how do you make the decision? You know you're playing with people's lives in many ways. So it

was tough. But I think I did the right thing in just waiting and not just saying oh, it's over, or we're going to go on, you know, being hard-headed about it.

MR: That's interesting because you anticipated a question, because most of us musicians got quickly very used to the phone ringing or an email saying those gigs you have, they're cancelled. But to be put in a position to cancel a gig yourself, it's a tough one.

VR: Yeah, yeah, yeah. And I still did, I did like actually a Batá ceremony that Saturday, and it was still not — I was aware of it and I was leery about doing it, but I just went ahead and did it anyway because it had been scheduled. And that was the last one, actually the 14th was the last function that I did. And after that we all went into quarantine and everything just got cancelled. I didn't have to call anybody, because it was sort of understood.

MR: Are you in touch with your band members in your Bronx-Conexion Orchestra?

VR: I've been in contact with Chembo, of course you met Chembo. I've spoken to Cascadú a few times. I have a weekly Zoom meeting — I don't hold it but my bass player sort of has like a conference Zoom meeting at 8:00 every Wednesday evening, so several Bronx members are involved in that. So that's our way of keeping in contact with each other. But some of the band members I haven't called but I will soon because the Nuyorican is thinking of opening as soon as we can. They're thinking about August, September. But then again, that depends on whether we can perform as a large group or not. So that we don't know.

MR: Being in the greater New York City area, you've been a hot spot. And up here we're now entering Phase 3. So more things are opening but still large gatherings with music is not on the list yet.

VR: Yeah. That's the big question right now, what's going to happen with that. Yes.

MR: I wonder, if this goes on for longer than we hope, are there things you're doing, I guess I'm referring to the big band, and the energy and time you put — I mean I'll set this up. I remember you talking about one of your chores as a band leader and that is putting the music back in the folders in the right order, and what a job that is.

VR: Yes, yes.

MR: So I'm wondering if you might get to the point where because you can't possibly do this now, you might consider do I want to do it again?

VR: I've thought about that. I've thought about whether as a matter of fact — I had a conversation with one of my trombone players, he called me out of the blue, and he was saying, "This might be it for us. Is it over? Am I done?" You know, "Am I going to play again?" But I don't want to give up. I've had the band now since 2012, that's going on 13 years in September. I would like to have the band into my later age for at least, give it another ten, fifteen years, if I can hold on to it. It's not easy, but as soon as I get the opportunity I'm just going to jump right back in. I'm keeping myself in shape by walking

every day and doing a little bit of exercise, I've been practicing. For two months I couldn't go to my practice studio to practice, you know, play the drums. But I stayed home and I practiced two, three hours, you know just doing rudiments and hand exercises and my chops are actually feeling good. So no, I'm going to hang in there. It's a baby that I gave birth to and I'm not going to let it go that easy you know. I'm determined.

MR: Good. I was hoping that would be your answer. Because we so much enjoyed your performance at Hamilton. Did you need to get into the online lessons with any students?

VR: Yes. I knew nothing about Zoom, Skype and all that stuff. I just, my wife was the one who downloaded Zoom and I've been doing online percussion lessons with my students. Actually I'm getting used to it. It's not that bad. The thing that I miss is if I want to demonstrate something they can't really see or feel me you know. That's what I miss. But in many ways I feel like I'm more organized because what I do is I keep a log of what we do and the progress that they're making, which I did before but I did it more mentally. But now I'm writing it. So on the next lesson I have my sheet in front of me, okay, here's number one let's do it. Okay we did it at 60 now next week 62. So I feel that I'm a bit more organized in many ways doing the Zoom lessons.

MR: That's an interesting phenomenon because I'm not the most organized person with lessons but I found that I did something similar with that. It's almost like silence and down time is more awkward when you're online Zooming with somebody so you want to make sure that you're ready. I'm not sure that's the way it is but when you're with someone doing a one-on-one you can do some improvising as you go along and react to the moment. And it's harder online.

VR: Yes, yes, yes, yes. Most definitely. But it's been working out. I don't want to stay with it forever but when I have to — a lot of people do it for a living, they give lessons online, so it's something we have to consider you know.

MR: Have you lost any friends or associates to the Covid-19?

VR: Thank God nobody close to me. You know people that I knew from before that I played with years ago passed away either from the Covid, but more from illness. Just last week I lost a friend, you know, that I knew, hadn't seen him in about ten years. He had complications of cancer and diabetes so he passed away. And there's been a few like that that have passed away. I think that I'm at the age where I'm going to see colleagues pass away so it's not expected, but that's the way it is, so it's happening. Luckily no family members have got the virus.

MR: I'm glad to hear that. Besides the lost income from gigs, what are you missing about not performing?

VR: Interacting with people, that's the main thing. Playing, like no matter how much you practice, no matter how much you know or play in your practice room, you have to play

with other bodies and feel that pull, that energy, and that's what I miss. I mean I do play with MP3s and that, but it's a set pace. It doesn't move with you. It doesn't react to you. So that's what I most — I just started getting together with some Batá players you know, with masks and all that. So I'm glad I'm doing that because I hadn't played the drum in about two months and I was afraid — if you don't play the drum you start forgetting things you know.

MR: Yeah. You lose that muscle memory I would imagine.

VR: Yes, yes. And all of a sudden you can't remember something so I'm glad I'm back into it.

MR: At the Nuyorican, do people dance?

VR: Occasionally. It's a small place but we encourage it. We have like the band and then there's like a set of chairs here, maybe 20 chairs and 20 over here, or maybe less. And then there's like an aisle and then next to the bars it's some space. So we have more enthusiastic people that come in and they'll get up and they'll dance, and we encourage it. It's not a dance place per se but we encourage it.

MR: I was thinking there's an added thing now with social distancing. Like I can imagine a bizarre scene like you can dance but don't get closer than six feet away.

VR: Yes. It's going to be hard to do that.

MR: Do you have any predictions — when your trombone player called you and said gee this could be the end for me as a musician, do you have a prediction about that?

VR: I think it depends on the person and how we handled it. Like for me, even if I was to stop playing in public it doesn't mean that I stop playing you know. I'm still going to be like well for the past three months I've been at home mostly. Like I said I practice, I've been studying. Every morning I get up I scan music, I scan documents, I usually start my day by doing that then I go on to study a score. I've been studying a Don Sebesky score lately and a Thad Jones. What I do is I write it out you know, all the parts, note by note. And then I can analyze it and see how it was done. That's the way I learned just by doing. And then I'll practice a little bit and this and that, and you know, it's never going to stop. I don't have to have a gig to reinforce myself that I'm a musician. It's always going to be in me. But of course I hope to be able to play in front of people soon, and in particular with my band. But it's not going to stop. But I think some people will give up. Because I've seen that in people where if they don't have a gig they don't practice. Why practice if I don't have a gig? But I think that's the wrong approach. You practice so that you'll be ready to move on when the opportunity presents itself. But that's my approach.

MR: Excellent. I'm going to put that in capital letters when we do the transcript.

VR: Yeah.

MR: I think it's terrific advice and a fine attitude. I was reading this morning about the disparity in how the pandemic has affected the African-American and Latino community and I'm not sure I have a question here but I wonder how that strikes you.

VR: Well according to the media more minorities are dying from the pandemic. I'm sure that's true, you know, many minorities and people of lower socioeconomic level don't have access to healthcare and this and that, so I'm sure it's happening. That's all I have to say. It is a factor. Sometimes being a Latino, our diet is not as good. You know like me of Mexican background, we eat a lot of cheese, a lot of meat. I remember my brother used to say, "I don't like soup because you don't bite into it. I need something to bite into." So sometimes our diet is not, you know, the best. So that could lead to diabetes and this and that, and further complications. So yeah, that's what it is.

MR: Is there anything, any beliefs or in your faith, we had a brief discussion about Santeria in our last interview. Is there anything in your faith or beliefs that might explain why this pandemic has happened, or how they would not justify it but how would your faith help you deal with it?

VR: Yeah, that's a hard question because even though I've been involved in, you know what we talked about this and that, I'm not deeply a religious person so I don't take, I don't let religion decide for me what I think in many ways. It just, I don't know, like I think some of the questions that you sent me that might have been a question is like why did it happen. Do I really know? I mean do we really know? Some say, in the media some say it might have been in a lab, it might have come from animals, more than likely my opinion is that it came from animals. But then the travel — you know if I want to go to China today I can be there by tomorrow, so the interchange of people back and forth is really what created this situation that we're in. So could it be avoided spiritually, this and that, could I make it go away by praying? I don't know.

MR: But it's an honest answer. The one crisis on top of another, in the midst of all this now we have a social crisis with the Black Lives Matter gatherings, some protests, and I'm going to go out on a limb here and I wonder if the Latino community, being classified as a minority, if their thinking is different about this current situation, rather than the white/Caucasian majority.

VR: Well you know I was a little young during the 60s, I was only in my early teens back in the 60s when we had the Civil Rights Movement. But later, like around 70, 71, that's when I became somewhat aware of what we call the Chicano Movement in Texas. That was the same type of thing as demanding equal rights for, in particular, Mexican Americans. Because you know of course the blacks, African-Americans have been discriminated with the restraints and all that stuff. The Mexican-Americans also suffered injustices in the Southwest you know? For one thing the whole Southwest was taken from

Mexico, you know that's a whole history in itself. So we do have a history of you know, discrimination, injustice. So I feel that it is important. When I hear about injustices to African-Americans I feel that it reflects what we need for us also, and for everybody, you know, all minorities. So yes, I do feel that it's important. And it goes, it covers everybody and any type of situation.

MR: I'm giving you all the hardball questions I have, Victor, I'll do one more. How do you feel about the role of the either local or state or federal government since this pandemic started?

VR: DeBlasio — I haven't seen him — my only source is CNN you know. So maybe I have a biased view, I don't know. DeBlasio hasn't made too many announcements, I haven't heard much from him from what I've seen. He seems to have blundered during the protests, you know, in controlling the city. I don't know. Maybe it's a hard situation, I don't know. So I don't want to make a judgement there. I've been very impressed the way Cuomo has been handling it. You know he goes on TV and he'll have statistics and he'll that about what we have to do and stuff like that. And it's never, it's only about us, about what we have to do to move forward. And I've been impressed with that. At the federal level, you know all about that. That was a slow response system, that and blaming everybody else. So I don't want to go into that. So I think it's been good at the state level. At the local level I haven't really paid that much attention so I'm not sure. But of course there's much more to do that has to be addressed. Right now people seem to be forgetting that we have a pandemic. I went outside to take a walk yesterday and I see a lot of people without masks. I see a lot of people in the street. I mean two months ago I would go outside and there would be almost nobody in the street so they say about 170,000 people might die by October, and we seem to not be concerned about it, as a national group. So that's a concern you know. We're more concerned about opening. And yet I want to open of course, and I want to start playing again, but we have to be careful what we do. Hopefully we'll do it correctly.

MR: Human nature is very confounding sometimes.

VR: Yes, yes, yes.

MR: Do you have a way that — is there a possibility that you might be able to start playing music with a smaller group rather than the whole orchestra?

VR: Yes. I've been thinking about — starting at the college level, we just had a meeting this past Tuesday. And normally we have a big band with four trumpets, four bones and five sax, just like Bronx-Conexion. But we're not sure whether we can teach a twenty-piece group, you know, in person. So right now they're saying more than likely it's going to go online. So that's not a problem for music theory classes, music history, this and that. But how do you rehearse twenty people online? So my solution to the problem will be —

unless they tell me differently — is to do small groups. I'll probably do sectionals, maybe with a piano and the guitars, this and that. Now as far as performing with the Bronx-Conexion, I have the big band which is a twenty-piece group, I have a nonet, which I've done only once I believe. We went to Philadelphia and the budget was not there for the full big band. So I do have a nine piece version of the band, and I also have a seven piece with two horns from another group, music from another group that I used to have like ten years ago. So yes, right now as a matter of fact I got contacted by some organization here in Queens where they do live concerts during the summer, and if it opens up they asked me for one to play, so they asked me for three prices. They asked me for three quotes: the full big band, and two smaller groups. So I put in for the big band, the nonet, and the seven piece. And if I have to I'll go that way. The Nuyorican, if they open up if they say I cannot do twenty pieces, I'll go down to whatever I have to — nine, ten, seven — just to keep it going. Because I don't want to lose the gig and then eventually hopefully it opens up and I'll get everybody back in. And I'm sure they'll understand, the guys, you know?

MR: Sure. They all do other things of course, but most of those other things aren't happening either.

VR: Yes, yes, yes.

MR: Well I think you could do a show just with the three of you playing your Batá drums.

VR: Oh definitely. As a matter of fact, Chembo is doing like a master class for the Nuyorican. I think he's on next Tuesday, I'll send you a link. I'll tell him to send you a link. And I know I'm going, word got to me that I'm going to be asked to do a master class for the Nuyorican just to keep the series going. And most definitely I could do a percussion ensemble. We haven't talked about it but I do have a percussion ensemble. We haven't done anything in a couple of years — it's called Cotimbo.

MR: Say that again?

VR: It's called Cotimbo. I guess conga, timbales, bo. So actually you saw the group when we did those percussion things at Hamilton. We didn't call it Cotimbo but I could do a presentation and we could play just do some bembe, you know some mambo, just percussion. So that's another possibility, either online or live. Another possibility if I can only play with four or five people is to get myself, a timbales or drumset, Chembo on congas, my wife on bongo, Cascadú on percussion, and a bass player. And we could do a rhythm section thing and just play. Have you ever heard "Puente in Percussion?"

MR: No.

VR: It's an album that Tito Puente did with Mongo Santamaria, Patato and some other percussionists and a bass player. [Scats] Then they would solo around that. So that's a possibility. I haven't thought about it. You just gave me the idea.

MR: Okay.

VR: Thank you.

MR: Okay well just to wrap up, when you get up in the morning do you put music on?

VR: Yes. I've been — it's funny you mention that because one of the things we talk about on Wednesdays when I meet with that Zoom meeting is that we recommend recordings that we listen to throughout the week and also movies that maybe we saw. So in the morning while I'm scanning or doing something I'll put on something. As you can see behind me I have a lot of vinyl. The top is all Latino stuff, the middle is jazz. So my original idea was to go one by one. But I must have at least 3000 records. There's no way I can go one by one. So I started out with Count Basie in the middle. I listened to some Quincy Jones and this and that. I pick something. Yesterday I was listening to Clifford Brown and Max Roach, that great album. Right now I'm in jazz. But there's a lot of Latino stuff that I haven't pulled out yet. So yes, in the morning I've been pushing myself to listen to something because the last few years I've gotten into the habit of not listening to music for the joy of it. Whenever I listen to something it's because I'm looking for something or studying something. There's always a purpose for listening to it. But what about just sitting down and listening to something for the joy of it. Now that I have a little bit more time I've been doing that, yes.

MR: Yes, I've been revisiting my Cannonball Adderley LPs.

VR: Uh huh.

MR: Did you ever hear of the Cannonball and I think it's called the Bossa Rio Sextet? I think Sergio Mendez was on it.

VR: I think I did because actually that's the A, so I listened to those first. Of course I listened to "Mercy, Mercy" with Joe Zawinul. And there was one Brazilian one that he did, I don't remember the title. That might be the one, I'll have to check it out.

MR: Very lovely.

VR: Right. Roy McCurdy on drumset. By the way I also started reading your book.

MR: Oh look at that.

VR: This is where I'm at, you know I read a little bit. It's really interesting, thank you. I love it.

MR: Thanks for saying so.

VR: It's under my computer right now but it's not forgotten.

MR: Okay. Well I've enjoyed reconnecting with you.

VR: Likewise, yes.

MR: And I can flash back to when you came to Hamilton and the sound of those drums still gets to me.

VR: Yes, yes, yes.

MR: It's like — playing in my memory, and there's something about it, it gets you in the heart.

VR: Yeah. I really enjoyed playing with the Hamilton jazz band.

MR: Yup.

VR: And playing with the director, I forgot his name but he was very gracious and very inviting.

MR: Right. And the students —

VR: And to see you playing. So I enjoyed it very much.

MR: All right. Well thanks for illuminating us about your thoughts on this, and I wish you the best. I'm going to stop recording and we can chat for another minute or so, if that's all right with you.

VR: Okay.

MR: All right, thanks, Victor.